The Moonshot Tape

By Lanford Wilson

DIANE is thirty-five. She has short hair, jeans and a T-shirt, socks, no shoes. When she reads, she uses dime-store reading glasses. She speaks to an interviewer, who would be sitting against the fourth wall. She is trying to be cordial, but she has a "to hell with it, let the chips fall where they may" directness that hides a natural warmth and also masks a pain and grievance of which she is only partially aware.

NOTE: *[words in brackets] are not found in the original text – modified for suitability for high school performance.*

DIANE: This isn't bad, this joint. As it turns out, the rooms are perfectly adequate, they're clean, the heat's a little eccentric, but there's a bathroom with at least a shower. . . The evening sessions, getting Mom to sleep, take it out of you. It was her idea to go there, insisted on it, looked forward to it almost, but. . . *(Pause.)* Half the inmates are insane or senile or something. The lady in Mom's room - She doesn't know if she has to go to the bathroom, if she's eaten, if she's slept. So she says, "Lady? Lady? Lady? Whatta I do now? Lady? Whatta I do now?" *(Pause.)* That's going to wear thin, I can tell. Even for Mom, who has the patience of the angels. *(She looks at the list.)* "Where do you get your ideas for stories?" *(She sighs)*

INTRODUCTION

Confession is not only good for the soul, but beneficial for the theater as well - especially when the characters spilling their secrets have been created by playwright Lanford Wilson.

In The Moonshot Tape, our confessor is Diane, a short story author, who has returned to her hometown to move her aging mother into a nursing home. During her stay, she is interviewed by a reporter from her old high school's newspaper – after all, she's become one of the most successful graduates of Mountain Grove High School. But memories of her childhood are brought back by the naive questioning of the student. What returns are tales of sexual abuse by her now-dead stepfather and how she tried to exorcise those experiences.

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DIANE: "Where do you get your ideas for stories?" *(She sighs, then thinks seriously.)* You know, sometimes-well, it's always, unfortunately, just yourself you're writing about, but sometimes they're blatantly autobiographical. My side of the story, that's always fun. Never underestimate the power and excitement of revenge. *(Without a beat she breaks off)* "Where do I get my ideas?" Sometimes I start writing something, it turns into a piece that's been kicking me around forever; and I think, Oh, good, I'm finally doing that. Then I'll go months with nothing. Like if you weren't here now I might be writing a story about a girl coming home to help her mother move into a nursing home. Or just coming back for a visit and seeing the town, or someone from school, or any of the things coming back home does to you. Being invaded by those memories, those times, those voices, the pictures. And the various lies you tell of your history to protect the guilty. So. *(She looks at the paper again, tired of this, exasperated, almost pissed.)*

"How much of an influence has Mountain Grove been on your writing comma your life?" Buckets. Whole bucketsful. *(Pause.)* I'm sorry. You've caught me at low ebb, or a bad time. I have all these feelings, guilt trips, ghosts, bombarding me here. *(Pause.)*

For instance, my father left Mom and me when I was five. Mom didn't remarry until I was eleven: Tom and Edith and little Sam, who was three and a half and never spoke. *(Pause.)* Mom was frail and quite a bit older than Tom and always the peacemaker; nothing was to upset the order of the household, the sanctity of the home we hear so much about. Just put a lid on it and let it boil. And Tom was the quietly expansive, friendly type that everyone loved. Good job at the cheese factory, nothing flashy or threatening, just a good ol' Joe who started coming into my room sometime during that first year. *(Pause.)*

He'd stand by the side of my bed in the dark, pull the covers back and feel my breasts, rub *[himself]* against my cheek, turn my head over, and *[well, I don't have to spell it out for you]*. Then he'd cover me up and go to the door. Stand there, very quiet, forever. . . I never knew why. . . then go back to bed. *(Pause.)* That was only when he drank. Maybe once

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every three weeks. The room would reek from him. Cigarette sweat and boilermakers. I thought, of course, that it was some sort of punishment.

You can't imagine how good I was. I'd help in the kitchen, set the table, do the dishes, wipe the counter, clean the refrigerator, do my homework for the next month, read all the elective outside-reading assignments, fall asleep, and in a few hours I'd wake up with his hand brushing my forehead and lie very still. The two or three times I tried to turn my head he yanked it back with such violence I thought he'd break my neck. So. Eleven, twelve, thirteen, fourteen, fifteen, sixteen. If you believe it. I put a lock on my door when I was fourteen; he took it off. I went to Mom, said, "Mom, at night, after you're asleep, Tom comes into my room"-and she slapped me halfway across the house. Told me never to lie again. *(Pause.)*

So I came back here, for our fifth high school reunion, contrived to get everyone but Tom out of the house one Sunday afternoon. Tom was very respectful. I was important, of course, and an adult now. And Tom had found God . . . . So I showed him how the police tied us up to take us off to jail - they hadn't actually, and as a matter of fact, I was never in jail, but it comes in handy from time to time to be able to tell a story.

So there he was, with his feet belted together and his hands tied behind his back, lying on the middle of the living-room floor. I wish you could have seen it gradually . . . dawn on him that he was helpless. . . . *(Pause. She lights a cigarette. Maybe she pours a couple of fingers of vodka and has a belt as well.)* Never underestimate the power and excitement of revenge. *(Pause.)*

I wandered into the kitchen, got myself a soda from the fridge. Tom started calling, "Diane? Where'd you go, honey? Diane, this ain't funny, sweetheart." I looked around the kitchen -- Mom had a regular slaughterhouse in her knife drawer. Mallets and cleavers and a collection of butcher knives that was absolutely sobering. But I selected the weapon of my trade - an indelible, permanent-ink, felt-tip pen that Mom used to mark packages of meat . . . and I went back into the room with Tom. I sat down beside him on the floor and very

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slowly started unbuttoning his shirt and pants, with him starting to say now, "Oh, don't do that, Diane, honey, I'm gonna tell your mother," if you can believe it.

I went back into the kitchen, got the scissors, scared him to death, but only to cut his clothes off him. I just said, "Tom, don't tell me you've forgot all our nights together."

He's yelling, "I don't know what you're talking about, you just dreamed that."

I said, "Why, Daddy, that's every little girl's dream-in the minds of men."

He's going, "Oh, God, no, oh, God forgive her." Maybe if he'd said, Oh, God, forgive *me* . . . and I told him, "And I'm gonna write you a little story, Tom, that I want you to treasure, 'cause I get about three thousand dollars for something like this." And I took that nice indelible pen, wiped the sweat off his pretty blank white hairless chest and wrote: "Once there was a little girl whose guardian came to see her in the night."

He's bucking around, yelling, "You're not really writin' that, don't mark me up." I said, "Oh, honey, you marked me up."

My story went something like - I'm saying it aloud, writing: "He liked to put his hands on her to excite himself, and he liked to rub himself on her red cheeks - her cheeks must have felt like flames. And when couldn't stand it any longer, he'd put it in her mouth to cool himself off. And that's how he took care of his little ward. And that's how his little ward took care of him. *(Pause.)*

Probably a little more Dickensian than most of my work. Of course, he was screaming and bucking. I wasn't proud of my penmanship, but under the circumstances . . . and I went slow enough to make sure it was legible. Then he was saying, "Stop it, don't do that. I don't do that anymore. I was drunk. It was the devil, darlin'," wailing like a revivalist.

So I got my overnight bag and got the car keys that had fallen out of his pocket onto the rug. And left him there, hogtied and inscribed in the middle of the floor. Naked as the day he was born-looking like the pot-gutted tattooed man. Then I stood in the doorway for a long

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while like he used to do. Only he wasn't pretending to be asleep; he was twisting around on the rug, yelling, "Untie me, dammit. Diane, where do you think you're a-goin'? Don't leave me here all marked up." I went out to the car, drove it to the airport, and left it there. *(Pause.)*

Mother was livid. He told her it was a game, but she didn't see the fun in it. She liked everything to be peaceful. So *she* came to visit *me*, I didn't come back here. Not until Tom got so bad that she was nursing him and couldn't leave. Right toward the end I came here to see her. I was only in the room with Tom for a few minutes. Tom said he'd tried to read my stories, but they were filthy and depressing, and he told me that writing was just lying and getting away with it. And I said, "No, Tom, writing is the only place I know of where you can tell the truth and get away with it." *(Pause.)* He died about two weeks later. *(Glancing at the list.)*

Why do I write short stories instead of novels? Obviously I like ending things, that's all I've done. You can end eight or ten stories in a space that you could only end one novel. I like tying things up or I wouldn't be here now; where it's so much fun with all those memories of childhood; walking back over Mountain Grove, where everything is sweet and fine and nobody has any secrets.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lanford Wilson
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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2005 National Qualifier
2007 National Qualifier
2010 National Qualifier
2014 National Qualifier
2015 National Qualifier
2016 National Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier
OH State Qualifier